Chapter Eighty-Four

Madness and Usurpation

Between 1383 and 1401, Charles VI loses his wits, and Richard II loses his throne

JOHN OF GAUNT had lost his palace to the Peasants' Revolt, but not his hopes of a throne.

His first wife, the heiress Blanche of Lancaster, had brought him the title Duke of Lancaster. After her death at the age of twenty-three (she had already borne John seven children, three of whom survived), he had remarried the seventeen-year-old Constance of Castile, daughter of the deposed and murdered king of Castile, Pedro the Cruel. The pretender to the throne, Pedro's half brother Enrique of Trastámara, had seized the throne of Castile with the help of the French; he knew that John of Gaunt hoped to claim it in the name of his wife.

"John, duke of Lancaster, made an urgent request [that] money should be entrusted to his charge . . . ," the *Chronica Maiora* says, "claiming that with this same money he would keep back the enemy from the coasts of England for a whole year. . . . The nobles, although unwillingly, agreed to this importunate request with . . . some bitterness of heart. . . . [T]he duke held such power in the kingdom that it was extremely inadvisable for them to go against his wishes." The fleet was not merely for defense of the coast from the French, which Enrique of Trastámara knew; when he heard of John of Lancaster's new fleet, it gave him a "great fright. . . . He judged that the duke would be sailing not only in defence of the sea but also in an attempt on his